Ashe's angry interjection about the SSNCo's boycott of Westerners. 'Any worker for the cause of the Company, [Ashe] thought or induced himself to think, deserved to be bound over to keep the peace.' 'Mr Ashe thought it a sin for anyone to work for the Swadeshi Company.' He was accused of consulting the BI's agent even as the proceedings were on and meeting him frequently in court. Like his master, the local sub-magistrate too had acted in the same manner intimidating local hotel keepers to send their customers to BI's ships. Fortunately, A.R. Cox, who succeeded Ashe in mid-April, 'though he tried to save his predecessor, could not be a party to such transactions as Mr Ashe was easily lending himself to'.[35]

In this charged situation, local people, overwhelmingly sympathetic to the Swadeshi cause and the company, expressed their resentment in various ways. On 1 May, BI's Newton, as he left his office on the Beach Road and stepped into his horse-drawn carriage, thrashed the driver in full public view for no apparent reason. In no mood to take it lying down, the driver confronted the durai and demanded an explanation. Unable to face this unprecedented defiance, Newton sneaked back into his office. The driver demanded that he be discharged immediately with full settlement of his dues and refused to let anyone take charge of the carriage until his demand was met. When threatened with police intervention, he boldly said, 'If a noble soul such as Chidambaram Pillai, who worked in the cause of poor people, is in jail, it mattered little if he too was to suffer the same fate.' Finally, Newton had to send for Varaprasadam Pillai, his loyal stooge, to mollify him. A shamefaced Newton kept low and did not use his carriage for the next few days.[36]

Invoking Fair Play

Little routine business could be transacted in this hostile atmosphere. It appears that the Swadeshi steamer services were disrupted for some time after the popular violence following VOC's arrest. SSNCo and its management, as well as the company's directors were all unnerved by the concerted intimidation by the government. The directors had expected the